

Crime **OILTHEFT**

furnace oil dealers such as Ashok Gupta, the Maninagar dealer, or Harshad Thakkar of Sidhpur or Salim Sareshwala of Ahmedabad. Every one of them has gone to jail more than three times for dealing in stolen crude oil from the pipelines of ONGC and the Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) but have continued to abet the crime with impunity after coming out on bail.

Last month, Bodio's gang, which targets only ONGC pipelines, made its first attempt on an IOC pipeline near Sanand, not far from Ahmedabad. The pipeline, which passes through the land of a local farmer, was carrying kerosene from the Vadodara refinery on that day. (Petrol, diesel and kerosene all pass from the same pipeline in IOC's case but on different days.) The Sarkhej modus operandi was adopted. Four people, including Kalu Baria, Bodio's hole drilling expert, identified a point on the IOC pipeline and dug 8 ft to get to the 16-inch diameter pipeline. They fixed a ready-made clamp on the pipeline before drilling the hole. Then they fixed their own pipe in the hole, the other end of which led to a room which worked as their pumping station. They attached a valve to the mouth of the pipe so that it could work as a tap for extracting fuel at will. A camouflaged trolley of a tractor or a normal tanker worked for transporting the oil from the pumping station to dealers like Gupta or Sareshwala. The farmland where the pumping station was set up was leased by Bodio in the name of Baria.

But Bodio's first attempt on an IOC pipeline ended in complete failure. On the very first day, kerosene leaked and flooded the entire area. Alarmed, the IOC staff informed the police and Bodio was once again in jail. This was fifth case of oil theft against him in a span of six years but was confident as ever that he would once again come out on

bail. This time, however, the state Government had decided to take firm steps to curb the racket.

Son of a wealthy farmer, Bodio leads one of the active half-a-dozen oil thief gangs and took to oil thievery owing to the debts that he had incurred because of heavy drinking and womanising. More than anything else it was Bodio's lifestyle that drew attention, comparable as it was with smugglers of yesteryears like Sukurnarain Bukhia. Says R.K. Patel, the deputy superintendent of police investigating the case: "It was Bodio's love for liquor and women that pushed him into a huge debt in 2002 despite coming from a very rich background. It was at this stage that he came in touch with an oil thief to earn easy money to clear his debt."

Apart from Bodio, there are other gangs active in Gujarat too. One of them is led by Vijay Kumar Patel alias Gatio of Mehsana who operates in Mehsana and Ahmedabad districts. Gatio has been arrested four times in the past five years. He has also been detained under the Prevention of Anti-Social Activities Act in the past but continues to steal oil with impunity, thanks to the fact that there is no special provision in the law that sternly deals with this anti-national activity. In fact, the present law treats crude oil theft as a simple theft case. In case of theft of petrol, diesel and kerosene, which are essential commodities, the law is only marginally stronger. This makes ONGC pipelines the preferred target of oil thieves more than the IOC ones which carry diesel, petrol and kerosene.

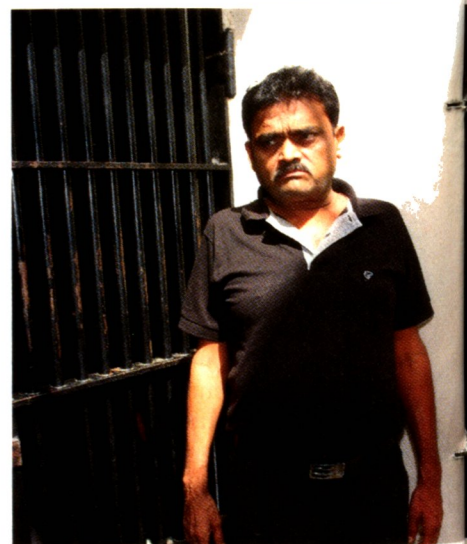
Stronger laws for fuels, however, haven't deterred the gang of Bansilal Sharma alias Fauji, said to be a former armyman from Naroda area, from targeting IOC pipelines. While



The Great **OIL STEAL**

Gangs of thieves thrive on lax laws

- 503 cases of theft of oil and fuel from ONGC and IOC pipelines have been filed in Gujarat since 2001. There has been no conviction in these cases so far.
- Nearly a dozen small and big oil theft gangs are operating.



Drilling into an oil pipeline takes hours which casts a shadow of doubt over their patrolling by the oil firms and police action.